

(Clockwise from top) A scene from *Indian Predator: Butcher of Delhi*; *The Karma Killings (2016)*, on the Nithari murders; and the docu series *My Daughter Joined a Cult*

that recreated the Delhi Police's investigation and arrest of the six men who raped a 22-year-old physiotherapy intern, underlined the horrifying hold of gendered violence in the capital. Hansal Mehta's *Scam 1992* (2020), on the other hand, turned a backward gaze on the rise and fall of Harshad Mehta, the streetsmart stockbroker involved in the 1992 securities scam.

That there is an eager audience for the true-crime genre in India can be gleaned from the success of *The Karma Killings* (2016), Netflix India's first true-crime offering, and *House of Secrets: The Burari Deaths* (2021), the streaming giant's most recent true-crime outing. The documentaries are about two of India's biggest true-crime mysteries: the Nithari murders and the Burari deaths. If *The Karma Killings* was a compelling indictment of the class-divide in society, *House of Secrets* contextualised how superstition and undiagnosed mental illnesses can wreak havoc. Both made for gripping television.

That's not to say that India's appetite for true-crime is a recent phenomenon. Even before the advent of streaming platforms, shows like *Crime Patrol*, known for its over-the-top recreation of real-life cases, ruled public consciousness. "As a viewing experience, there is always the thrill of watching something unbelievable happen, coupled with the sense of relief that it is not happening to you. These two feelings explain why true crime has always enthralled Indian viewers," says Chandni Ahlawat Dabas, who leads Originals & Special Projects at INDIA TODAY and has worked on the second instalment of *Indian Predator*.

But the future of the genre, and whether India will keep seeing true-crime commissions, depends on how well creators are able to localise the origins and consequences of crime and punishment. "I would love to see themes that explore politics, caste, class and our relationships with crimes," says filmmaker Naman Sariya, who recently helmed *My Daughter Joined a Cult*, a 2022 Discovery+ docu-series that spotlights victims of the rape-accused godman Nithyananda. Saraiya concludes that it's the diversity of stories that sets the genre apart in the country. "Besides, how many times can one watch a story that begins somewhere in Texas, and a jaded, languid, drawl-heavy cop leads you down some case that could've wrapped up in three episodes instead of six?" ■

–Poulomi Das

Indian true crime documentaries have taken inspiration from the biggest news stories to examine the state of the nation

PLAYLIST

CRIME IN REAL TIME

True-crime podcasts that range from fun to urgent



MY FAVORITE MURDER (2016–)

As comedians Karen Kilgariff and Georgia Hardstark take turns to recount their favourite tales of murder, they tap into a community of true-crime fans who think of murder as escapist entertainment.

SERIAL (2014–)

Detailing the conviction of Adnan Syed, who was sentenced to life for the 1999 murder of his ex-girlfriend, *Serial* is an essential entry-point into the canon. The podcast earned a generation of listeners because of how it challenged narratives.

BELIEVED (2018-2021)

A gripping piece of reportage, *Believed* traces the story of how former USA Gymnastics doctor Larry Nassar sexually abused girls and women for decades.

